



A lion frieze from the Processional Way in Babylon, which was built around 600 BCE and ran through the heart of the city to the Ishtar Gate.



The Assyrian Empire

From its core around Assur and Nineveh, the Assyrian empire grew to encompass Babylonia, Media, Elam, Urtu, Syria, and Egypt.

led the war against neighboring Alba Longa, which ultimately led to that city's destruction and the deportation of its population to Rome, in the **first major Roman expansion**. The fourth king, **Ancus Marcius** (641–617 BCE), expanded Roman territory toward the coast, and founded Rome's great port of Ostia at the mouth of the Tiber. His successor, **Tarquinius Priscus** (616–578 BCE) was the fifth king of Rome and one of the city's greatest kings. He came from an Etruscan background, a sign of the high level of Etruscan influence over the early city of Rome. Tarquinius Priscus won a series of victories over the Sabines, the Latins, and the Etruscans, who all competed with Rome for dominance over central Italy. He is also said to have established the public games in Rome.

THE ASSYRIANS HAD FINALLY CONQUERED BABYLON

in 691 BCE, partially destroying the city. Reconstruction work began under Esarhaddon (680–669 BCE), and by 652 BCE Babylon had recovered its importance and became the center for a **major revolt** led by Shamash-shuma-ukin against his younger brother Ashurbanipal. It took **four years of war** to suppress the Babylonians and their Elamite allies, and the fighting drained Assyria's ability to hold on to its empire. By 630 BCE, Assyria had lost Egypt and Palestine, and in 626 BCE the **Babylonians regained their independence**. By 616 BCE Babylon was strong enough to invade Assyria, aided by the Medes (whose base was in northwestern Iran). In 612 BCE the Babylonians, Medes, and Scythians sacked the Assyrian capital of Nineveh. The **Assyrian empire crumbled**.

A remnant of the Assyrian army regrouped and established a small kingdom around Harran, but by 609 BCE this, too, had fallen.

The **Scythians** formed part of a culture of **nomadic horsemen** which held a large territory on the steppes north of the Caucasus from around 800 BCE. In 652 BCE they forced the Medes to submit

to them and the Scythian King Bartatua was even sufficiently influential to be given an Assyrian princess as his wife. The **alliance with Assyria** survived into the reign of his son Madyes, but around 615 BCE the Scythians switched sides and played a **key role in Assyria's destruction**.

Their Median subjects soon turned on them and around 590 BCE the Scythians retreated north. In the Greek world, there was a growing movement to **establish colonies** in the Mediterranean. Among the earliest were in Italy, including **Syracuse**, founded around 733 BCE. In North Africa, Greek settlers founded **Cyrene** (in Libya) in about 630 BCE, and **Massilia** (Marseilles) around

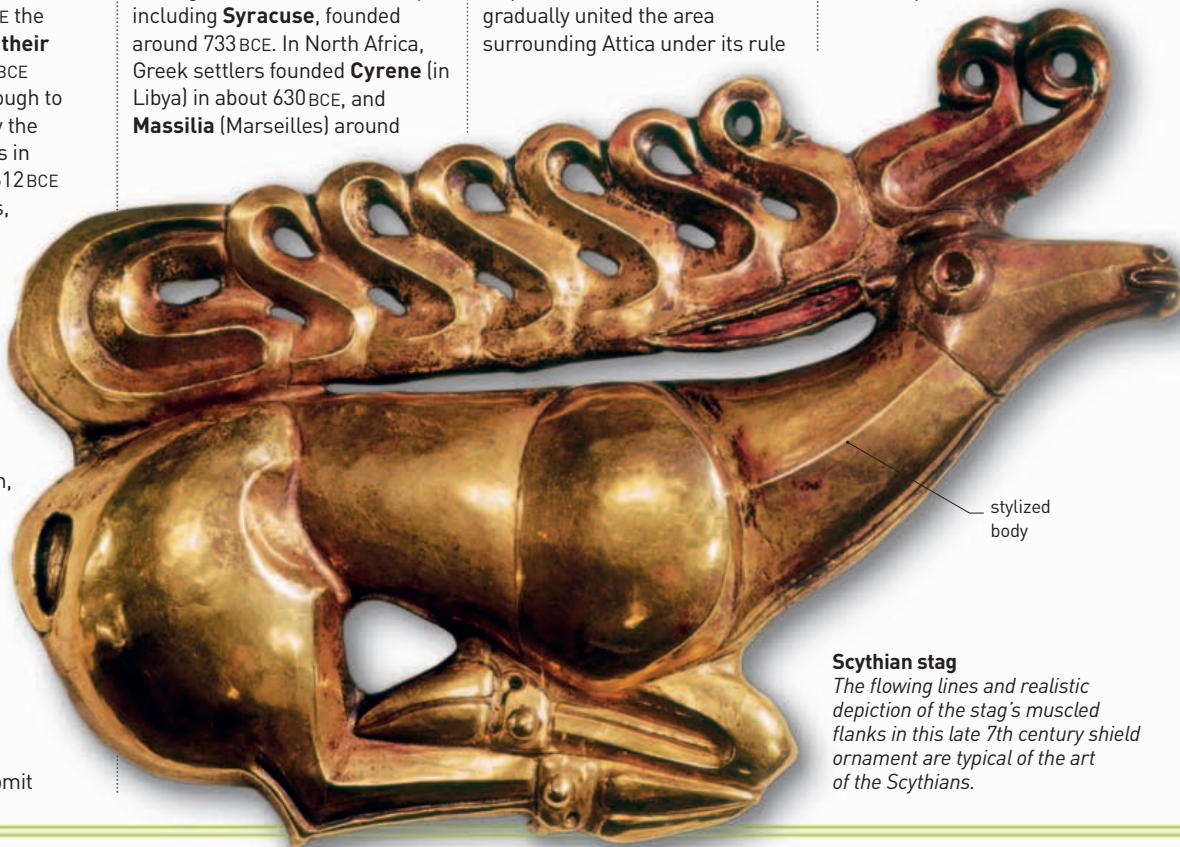
600 BCE. New cities were established as far west as Spain, and around the Black Sea coast.

In Greece itself, the **city-state of Sparta** was establishing its dominance in the Peloponnese. A defeat by the city-state of Argos, in 669 BCE, was followed by military reforms and victory against the Messenians (660–650 BCE). By 600 BCE, **Sparta had conquered** almost all the southern Peloponnese and established a stratified social system.

Sparta's future rival, **Athens**, gradually united the area surrounding Attica under its rule

in the 8th century BCE. The hereditary monarchy was replaced by nine "archons," chosen annually. Shortly after a damaging popular uprising by Cylon in 632 BCE, Athens received its first law code, drafted by Draco in 621 BCE. The **Draconian law** was later known for the severity of the punishments it prescribed.

To the south of Egypt the **state of Napata** became a power of the first order, conquering Egypt under Piankhy (751–716 BCE) and controlling it under after the death of Taharqa (690–664 BCE).



Scythian stag

The flowing lines and realistic depiction of the stag's muscled flanks in this late 7th century shield ornament are typical of the art of the Scythians.

652 BCE Babylonian rebellion threatens Assyrian rule, but is put down (ends 649 BCE)

c. 650 BCE Age of "tyrants" begins in many Greek states

c. 650 BCE Iron technology reaches Zhou China

650 BCE First coins minted in Lydia

650 BCE Meroe founded (in modern Sudan)

647 BCE Ashurbanipal sacks Susa

648 BCE Babylon surrenders to Ashurbanipal

630 BCE Sparta wages war against the Messenians

631 BCE Ashurbanipal dies

626 BCE Greek colony of Cyrene founded (in modern Libya)

626 BCE Nabopolassar becomes ruler of Babylon, founding Neo-Babylonian dynasty

621 BCE First Athenian law code, Code of Draco

625 BCE Periander takes power as Tyrant in Corinth

616 BCE Tarquin, an Etruscan, becomes king of Rome

620 BCE Foundation of Greek colony of Tartessus in Spain

612 BCE Assyrian empire collapses in face of attacks from Medes and Babylonians

615 BCE The Medes, an emerging power, defeat the Scythians

608 BCE Necho II of Egypt invades Judah

609 BCE Residual Assyrian state, Harran, captured by Babylonians and Medes; Assyrian state disappears forever

605 BCE Nebuchadnezzar II succeeds to the throne of Babylon

604 BCE Traditional date for the birth of Lao Tzu, the founder of Taoism